

Harrison Bergeron

By: Kurt Vonnegut

Plot Overview

It is the year 2081. Because of Amendments 211, 212, and 213 to the Constitution, every American is fully equal, meaning that no one is stupider, uglier, weaker, or slower than anyone else. The Handicapper General and a team of agents ensure that the laws of equality are enforced.

One April, fourteen-year-old Harrison Bergeron is taken away from his parents, George and Hazel, by the government. George and Hazel aren't fully aware of the tragedy. Hazel's lack of awareness is due to average intelligence. In 2081, those who possess average intelligence are unable to think for extended stretches of time. George can't comprehend the tragedy because the law requires him to wear a radio twenty-four hours a day. The government broadcasts noise over these radios to interrupt the thoughts of intelligent people like George. Hazel and George are watching ballerinas dance on TV. Hazel has been crying, but she can't remember why. She remarks on the prettiness of the dance. For a few moments, George reflects on the dancers, who are weighed down to counteract their gracefulness and masked to counteract their good looks. They have been handicapped so that TV viewers won't feel bad about their own appearance. Because of their handicaps, the dancers aren't very good. A noise interrupts George's thoughts. Two of the dancers onscreen hear the noise, too; apparently, they are smart and must wear radios as well.

Hazel says she would enjoy hearing the noises that the handicappers dream up. George seems skeptical. If she were Handicapper General, Hazel says, she would create a chime noise to use on Sundays, which she thinks would produce a religious effect. The narrator explains that Hazel strongly resembles Diana Moon Glampers, Handicapper General. Hazel says she would be a good Handicapper General, because she knows what normalcy is. Before being interrupted by another noise, George thinks of his son, Harrison.

Hazel thinks George looks exhausted and urges him to lie down and rest his "handicap bag," forty-seven pounds of weight placed in a bag and locked around George's neck. He says he hardly notices the weight anymore. Hazel suggests taking a few of the weights out of the bag, but he says if everyone broke the law, society would return to its old competitive ways. Hazel says she would hate that. A noise interrupts the conversation, and George can't remember what they were talking about.

On TV, an announcer with a speech impediment attempts to read a bulletin. He can't overcome his impediment, so he hands the bulletin to a ballerina to read. Hazel commends him for working with his God-given abilities and says he should get a raise simply for trying so hard. The ballerina begins reading in her natural, beautiful voice, then apologizes and switches to a growly voice that won't make anyone jealous. The bulletin says that Harrison has escaped from prison.

A photo of Harrison appears on the screen. He is wearing the handicaps meant to counteract his strength, intelligence, and good looks. The photo shows that he is seven feet tall and covered in 300 pounds of metal. He is wearing huge earphones, rather than a small radio, and big glasses meant to blind him and give him headaches. He is also wearing a red rubber nose and black caps over his teeth. His eyebrows are shaved off.

After a rumbling noise, the photo on the Bergerons' TV screen is replaced with an image of Harrison himself, who has stormed the studio. He says that he is the emperor, the greatest ruler in history, and that everyone must obey him. Then he rips off all of his handicaps. He looks like a god. He says that the first woman brave enough to stand up will be his empress. A ballerina rises to her feet. Harrison removes her handicaps and mask, revealing a beautiful woman.

He orders the musicians to play, saying he will make them royalty if they do their best. Unhappy with their initial attempt, Harrison conducts, waving a couple of musicians in the air like batons, and sings. They try again and do better. After listening to the music, Harrison and his empress dance. Defying gravity, they move through the air, flying thirty feet upward to the ceiling, which they kiss. Then, still in the air, they kiss each other.

Diana Moon Glampers comes into the studio and kills Harrison and the empress with a shotgun. Training the gun on the musicians, she orders them to put their handicaps on. The Bergerons' screen goes dark. George, who has left the room to get a beer, returns and asks Hazel why she has been crying. She says something sad happened on TV, but she can't remember exactly what. He urges her not to remember sad things. A noise sounds in George's head, and Hazel says it sounded like a doozy. He says she can say that again, and she repeats that it sounded like a doozy.

Character List

Harrison Bergeron —

The son of George and Hazel Bergeron. Fourteen years old and seven feet tall, Harrison seems to be the most advanced model the human species can produce. He is a genius who is also absurdly strong, a dancer who can also break out of prison, and a self-proclaimed emperor. If Harrison can't succeed in overthrowing the government, Vonnegut suggests, no one can. Harrison's assassination on live television means that the last, best hope of Americans has failed and there is no longer any chance of escaping the laws of equality.

Harrison represents the part of the American people that still longs to try hard, flaunt their attributes, and outpace their peers. At age fourteen, Harrison is a physical specimen: seven feet tall, immensely strong, and extremely handsome. The government does everything in its power to squelch Harrison, forcing him to wear huge earphones to distort his thinking, glasses to damage his sight and give him headaches, three hundred pounds of metal to weigh him down, a ridiculous nose, and black caps for his teeth. But none of the government's hindrances, including jail, can stop Harrison. His will to live as a full human being is too strong. The government calls Harrison a genius, but he is remarkable less for his brains than for his bravery and self-confidence. When he escapes from jail, he is utterly convinced that he will succeed in overthrowing the government.

In addition to his remarkable strength of body and will, Harrison has an artistic, romantic soul. He removes his empress's handicaps with the careful touch of a sculptor. He instructs the musicians in their craft, showing them exactly how he wants them to play by singing to them. He dances so beautifully that he manages to defy gravity, springing thirty feet to the ceiling with his empress, where he kisses her. Vonnegut hints that Harrison is something of a sexual superman, and it is clear that if he succeeds in his plan to overthrow the government, he will father a line of superior children. But the murder of Harrison and his empress shows that in the America of 2081, those who are brave enough to show off their gifts will not be allowed to live, much less procreate.

George Bergeron —

Harrison's father and Hazel's husband. To counteract his physical strength, George must wear weights around his neck. George, an intelligent man, must also wear a radio that prohibits him from thinking deeply. The noises broadcast at twenty-second intervals by this radio interfere with George's natural tendency toward intense thought. Despite his pensive nature, George is not bold. He believes in obeying the law and avoiding risks. He is also emotionally barren, urging his wife to forget her sadness and reacting to his son's televised adventure by going to the kitchen for a beer.

George is an everyman, a character most readers will understand and relate to. Smart and sensitive, George has been crippled by the government's handicapping program. He makes intelligent remarks and thinks analytically about society, but his mind is stunted. Every twenty seconds, noises broadcast by the government interrupt his thoughts, preventing sustained concentration. In addition to being smart, George is also stronger than the average man and must wear forty-seven pounds around his neck to weigh himself down. Although George is mentally and physically gifted, he is spiritually unremarkable. When Hazel suggests that he removes a few of the lead balls from the bag that weighs him down, George refuses to entertain the idea, unwilling to risk jail. A law-abiding man, he believes that America in 2081 is a much better place than it was in the old days, when competition existed. George, a slightly above-average person with a healthy respect for the rules, stands in for the reader, who may be all too willing to go along with government regulations that thwart individual freedoms and uniqueness. By showing us the unhappiness of George's existence, Vonnegut asks us to question our own passivity and perhaps even our support for the laws of the land.

Hazel Bergeron —

Harrison's mother and George's wife. Scatterbrained, dumb, and helpless, Hazel is also sweet and well intentioned. For every nonsensical comment she makes about the wonderful work the Handicapper General is doing or the commendable effort made by the incompetents on television, she makes a kind remark to George or sheds a few tears for her son's plight. Hazel is characterized as an average American.

Hazel is a one-woman cautionary tale, an average American in an age when "average" has come to mean "stupid." She does not need a radio permanently affixed to her ear, as George does, because she was never capable of sustained thought. Hazel applauds those who are as incapable as she is, cheering on the unimpressive ballerinas and praising the pathetic performance of the announcer who cannot overcome his speech impediment. Hazel is a dim bulb, but she is also kind. She worries about George and suggests that he remove a few of his weights while he is at home, and she weeps over her son, although she cannot keep him in mind for more than a few seconds at a time. But Hazel is a cautionary tale precisely because her kindness makes no difference. Her stupidity overwhelms her good nature, preventing her from recognizing the absurdity of her society, let alone doing anything to change it.

Diana Moon Glampers —

The Handicapper General of the United States. Diana Moon Glampers is in charge of dumbing down and disabling those who are above average. It is her minions who enforce the handicap laws and create new hindrances for superior beings such as Harrison. A woman much like Hazel, Diana Moon Glampers kills Harrison and his empress and threatens to murder the musicians if they don't put on their handicaps.

The Ballerina-Turned-Announcer —

A dancer. George and Hazel can see that she is the best ballerina because she wears an immense amount of weight. She also wears a terrible mask to cover up what must be extreme beauty. When the announcer gives her the news to read, she speaks briefly in a beautiful voice before apologizing and making her voice ugly.

The Empress —

A dancer, possibly the same character as the ballerina-turned-announcer.

This dancer becomes Harrison's empress after he says the first woman to stand will be his mate. After Harrison removes her mental handicap, weights, and mask, she performs a lovely dance with him before being killed by Diana Moon Glampers.

The Announcer —

A newscaster. The announcer has a severe speech impediment, as do all announcers, and cannot manage to read the news about Harrison's jailbreak.

Themes, Motifs, and Symbols

Themes

The Danger of Total Equality

In "Harrison Bergeron," Vonnegut suggests that total equality is not an ideal worth striving for, as many people believe, but a mistaken goal that is dangerous in both execution and outcome. To achieve physical and mental equality among all Americans, the government in Vonnegut's story tortures its citizens. The beautiful must wear hideous masks or disfigure themselves, the intelligent must listen to earsplitting noises that impede their ability to think, and the graceful and strong must wear weights around their necks at all hours of the day. The insistence on total equality seeps into the citizens, who begin to dumb themselves down or hide their special attributes. Some behave this way because they have internalized the government's goals, and others because they fear that the government will punish them severely if they display any remarkable abilities. The outcome of this quest for equality is disastrous. America becomes a land of cowed, stupid, slow people. Government officials murder the extremely gifted with no fear of reprisal. Equality is more or less achieved, but at the cost of freedom and individual achievement.

The Power of Television

Television is an immensely powerful force that sedates, rules, and terrorizes the characters in "Harrison Bergeron." To emphasize television's overwhelming importance in society, Vonnegut makes it a constant presence in his story: the entire narrative takes place as George and Hazel sit in front of the TV. Television functions primarily as a sedative for the masses. Hazel's cheeks are wet with tears, but because she is distracted by the ballerinas on the screen, she doesn't remember why she is crying. The government also uses television as a way of enforcing its laws. When dangerously talented people like Harrison are on the loose, for example, the government broadcasts warnings about them. They show a photograph of Harrison with his good looks mutilated and his strength dissipated. The photo is a way of identifying the supposedly dangerous escapee, but it is also a way of intimidating television viewers. It gives them a visual example of the handicaps imposed on those who do not suppress their own abilities. Television further turns into a means of terrorizing the citizens when Diana Moon Glampers shoots Harrison. The live execution is an effective way of showing viewers what will happen to those who dare to disobey the law.

Motifs

Noise

The noises broadcast by the government increase in intensity and violence during the course of the story, paralleling the escalating tragedy of George's and Hazel's lives. When the story begins, a buzzer sounds in George's head as he watches the ballerinas on TV. As he tries to think about the dancers, who are weighed down and masked to counteract their lightness and beauty, the sound of a bottle being smashed with a hammer rings in his ears. When he thinks about his son, he is interrupted by the sound of twenty-one guns firing, an excessively violent noise that foreshadows Harrison's murder. Thoughts about the laws of equality and the competition that existed in the old days are shattered by the sound of a siren, a noise that suggests the extent to which the government has literally become the thought police. As Harrison barges into the television studio, George hears a car crash, a noise that connotes the injury of multiple people. The noise that interrupts George roughly at the same time that his son is being executed on live TV is described only as "a handicap signal," an ominously vague phrase. Vonnegut suggests that the noise is so awful that it can't be mentioned, just as the murder of Harrison is so awful that George and Hazel can't fully comprehend it. The final noise George hears is that of a riveting gun, an appropriate echo of the way Diana Moon Glampers killed Harrison.

Symbols

Harrison Bergeron

Harrison represents the spark of defiance and individuality that still exists in some Americans. He has none of the cowardice and passivity that characterize nearly everyone else in the story. Rather, he is an exaggerated alpha male, a towering, brave, breathtakingly strong man who hungers for power. When he storms into the TV studio and announces that he is the emperor, the greatest ruler who has ever lived, he sounds power-mad and perhaps insane. At the same time, however, his boastfulness is exhilarating. It is an exaggerated expression of the defiant urge to excel that some Americans still feel. When Harrison rips off his steel restraints and handicaps, the physical strength and beauty he reveals reminds some viewers that underneath their own restraints and handicaps, they too are still talented or lovely. But in the end, Harrison, symbol of defiance, is killed in cold blood by Diana Moon Glampers, the administrator of government power. The quick, efficient murder suggests that if a defiant spirit still exists in America in 2081, its days are numbered.

Vonnegut's Political and Social Critique

"Harrison Bergeron" offers vigorous political and social criticisms of both America in general and the America of the 1960s. The political system depicted in Vonnegut's story is distinctly American and founded on the principles of egalitarianism, which holds that people should be equal in every way. Equality is a beloved principle enshrined in America's constitution in the phrase "All men are created equal," but Vonnegut suggests that the ideals of egalitarianism can be dangerous if they are interpreted too literally. If the goal of equality is taken to its logical conclusion, we may decide that people must be forced to be equal to one another in their appearance, behavior, and achievements. "Harrison Bergeron" can also be interpreted as a direct critique of communism. In the 1960s, America was engaged with Russia in the Cold War and had recently struggled through the McCarthy era, when suspected communists were accused and blacklisted from artistic, literary, and political communities. The futuristic American society of "Harrison Bergeron" operates on communist principles, supporting the idea that wealth and power should be distributed equally and class hierarchies should not exist. Like the accused communists of the McCarthy era, anyone not conforming to society's accepted standards—in a reversal of sorts, anyone not adhering to the communist structure—is sought out and punished. In his story, Vonnegut argues that such principles are foolish. It is unnatural to distribute wealth and power equally, he suggests, and it is only by literally handicapping the best and brightest citizens that the misguided goal of equal distribution can be attained. Similarly, it is unnatural to seek out and punish those who reject social norms.

Some modern readers have interpreted the dystopia depicted in "Harrison Bergeron" as a preview of what might happen to America if such trends as psychiatric drugs and political correctness are allowed to proliferate. The characters in Vonnegut's story are passive, unthinking, and calm. Although the means of achieving this mental state are externally applied to the body, rather than internally applied to the mind, some readers draw a parallel between the noises that destroy George's ability to think and the drugs that make modern Americans tranquil and detached. These critics argue that the characters in "Harrison Bergeron," who lack all passion, intelligence, and creative ability, should be interpreted as a warning about what happens to the members of a society that prizes calm happiness above artistry or intelligence. Other readers see "Harrison Bergeron" as a socially conservative argument against political correctness. Vonnegut himself has connected the story to recent attempts to make people equal using the language of political correctness. According to this argument, the respectful treatment of all marginalized groups may be a slippery slope, as "Harrison Bergeron" suggests. If we begin with the equal treatment of male athletes and their weaker female counterparts, for example, we may end with the insistence that ugly people should be treated as if they are beautiful, and so forth.

Humor

"Harrison Bergeron," while full of dark themes, is also full of humor, which makes Vonnegut's serious message both easier to digest and more bitter. Almost every grim event in "Harrison Bergeron" is accompanied by a sly joke or moment of melancholy comedy. For example, the narrator explains that ballerinas are weighed down and masked to hide their lightness and beauty. This deeply sinister image is leavened when we learn that such measures are meant to save viewers from the pain of feeling that they themselves look like "something the cat drug in" in comparison to the dancing beauties on their television screens. Later, the fearful announcement about Harrison's escape is accompanied by a mournful joke: the announcer has a speech impediment so bad that he must hand over the important news to a nearby ballerina so that she can read it. In a second joke, Hazel says she thinks the incompetent announcer should get a raise simply for trying hard. The pain of the ballerina-turned-announcer, who must hide the loveliness of her own voice, is mitigated by Vonnegut's description of her disguised voice as a "grackle squawk."

Even the most horrifying moments in the story are characterized by Vonnegut's dark brand of humor. We learn that Hazel, a sweet but deeply stupid woman, is very similar to Diana Moon Glampers, the Handicapper General of the United States. Although it's upsetting to discover that the country is being run by imbeciles like Hazel, it is hard not to laugh at Hazel's idea for using religiously themed noises on Sundays to interrupt the thoughts of smart people like George. When Hazel and George attempt to discuss the difference between the competitive society of yesteryear and the America they live in, George's respect for the laws that have crippled him is heartbreaking. But the total breakdown of the conversation, brought about by George's and Hazel's inability to remember what they were talking about mere seconds earlier, produces a comical effect. Humor comes to the fore even after the Harrison's murder. In a disturbing exchange, George urges Hazel to "forget sad things" such as whatever made her cry (neither of them seem to know that their son's murder caused her tears). She answers that she always does forget sad things. Just after this conversation, George is interrupted by a noise that Hazel says sounded like a doozy. In a final bit of broad comedy, George, agreeing, says she can say that again, and Hazel repeats her remark verbatim. The effect is funny and a bit creepy, as the extent of the Bergerons' lack of self-awareness becomes fully clear.

Important Quotations Explained

1. "I think I'd make a good Handicapper General."

"Good as anybody else," said George.

"Who knows better'n I do what normal is?" said Hazel.

This passage appears near the beginning of the story. Vonnegut seems to suggest that Hazel's similarity to Diana Moon Glampers is disturbing because it means that the country is being run by people just as clueless as Hazel. When George says that Hazel is as "[g]ood as anybody else," we get the idea that she is just as confused and incapable of serious thought as every other average American living in the year 2081. Hazel's confidence in her understanding of "normal" is both funny and sinister. Her self-confidence in understanding "normal" is amusing, especially because it comes on the heels of her ludicrous suggestion that the government should interrupt thoughts on Sundays with religious-sounding chimes. But it is also a disturbing and subtle reminder that in this futuristic America, the people who run the country are in power not because of their brains or savvy, but because of their normalcy.

2. "The minute people start cheating on laws, what do you think happens to society?"

. . . . A siren was going off in [George's] head.

"Reckon it'd fall all apart," said Hazel.

"What would?" said George blankly.

"Society," said Hazel uncertainly. "Wasn't that what you just said?"

"Who knows?" said George.

This quotation, which appears near the beginning of the story, exemplifies the meandering, nonsensical human interactions that have become standard in Vonnegut's fictional America. Because he is smart, George is able to formulate an idea that society would disintegrate if people disregarded the laws and to pose that idea as a hypothetical question. But because his thinking is interrupted by one of the innumerable noises the government broadcasts over his radio, he loses track of the conversation completely. Even though Hazel is able to follow his reasoning, he can't remember what he was talking about moments before, and she isn't bright enough to get him back on track. The disturbing implication is that America's laws of equality go unchallenged not because citizens believe in them deeply but because they are too bewildered to figure out what they think of the laws in the first place. If George were able to think in peace for a few hours, he might come to believe that the laws he defends are absurd. However, these laws, against which he would likely protest if he could, are the ones that prevent him from thinking for more than a few seconds at a stretch.

3. [T]hey remained suspended in air . . . and they kissed each other for a long, long time.

. . . . Diana Moon Glampers . . . came into the studio with a double-barreled ten-gauge shotgun. She fired twice, and the Emperor and the Empress were dead before they hit the floor.

Harrison's midair dance with his empress near the end of the story is the only moment of unadulterated beauty in "Harrison Bergeron," and its brutal conclusion suggests the beginning of still darker days for America. Harrison is as amazing as the rest of the world is dull. In a narrative full of stupidity, mediocrity, and terror, Harrison brings strength and beauty into the story by removing his and the empress's weights and disguises. Whereas his parents are so compromised that they can hardly put two logical sentences together and merely sit in front of the TV like automatons, Harrison is a whirlwind of activity. He bursts into the studio, takes control, and forces the musicians to play lovely music instead of hackneyed tripe. His physical vigor is superhuman: defying the laws of gravity, he manages to suspend himself and his empress thirty feet above the ground. The long kiss he exchanges with her also provides the only moment of sensual pleasure in the story. But Diana Moon Glampers interrupts Harrison's dance almost as soon as it has begun. The spare, unflinching language with which Vonnegut narrates her murder of the emperor and empress mirrors the cold, inhuman nature of the deed. It is clear that for all his braggadocio, Harrison never had a chance at unseating the government for good.